

The Brandberg Massif

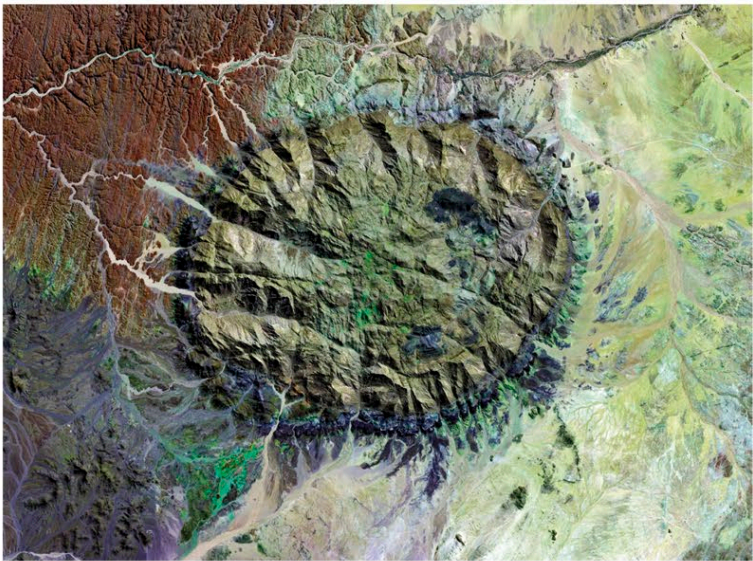
An isolated, dome-shaped mountain, or inselberg, that towers over the Sun-scorched gravel plains of the northwestern Namib Desert



The Brandberg formed around 130 million years ago when a large glob of magma from deep in Earth's crust pushed up through the surrounding rock layers before solidifying. Later, the granite mass was exposed by erosion of the surrounding rocks.

The burning mountain

The Brandberg is the highest mountain in Namibia, with its most elevated point at an altitude of 8,442 ft (2,573 m). The indigenous San people call it the "burning mountain" because it appears to glow red in the light of the setting Sun. With its considerable height and breadth, the Brandberg influences the local climate, drawing more rain to its flanks than the desert below. The rain slowly seeps out through springs. Unique animal and plant species thrive in its high-altitude environment, and prehistoric cave paintings decorate rock faces hidden within ravines around the base of the mountain.



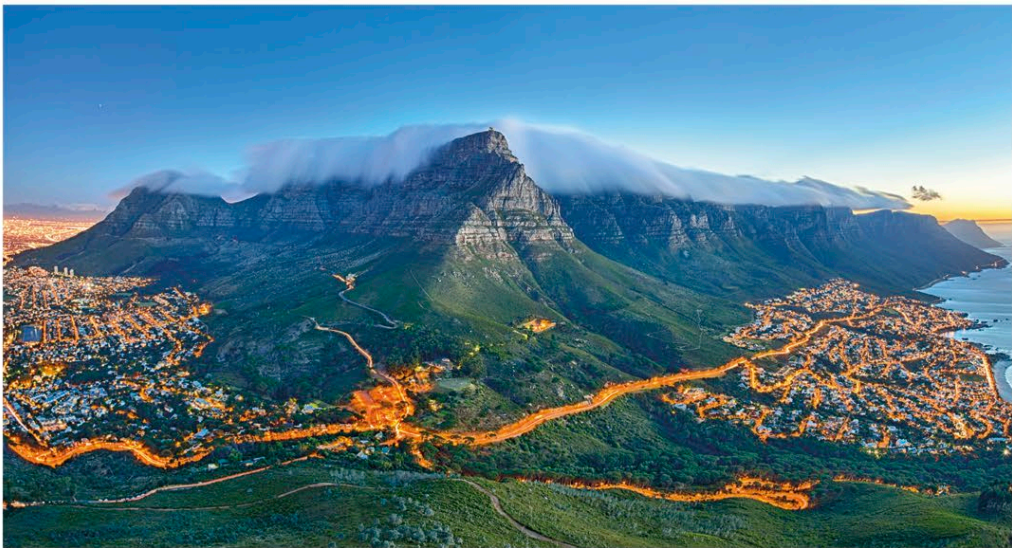
◁ RING OF ROCKS

The Brandberg is around 14 miles (23 km) long and 12 miles (20 km) wide, and has a rugged, undulating surface. A ring of dark, steep-sided rocks encircle the granite mass.



Table Mountain

A long, flat-topped mountain that forms a dramatic backdrop to the city of Cape Town



Approximately 2 miles (3 km) long and edged by impressive cliffs, Table Mountain is one of the most iconic landmarks in Africa. With its high point at 3,563 ft (1,086 m), it lies at the northern end of a sandstone mountain range that terminates about 30 miles (50 km) to the south at the Cape of Good Hope. Table Mountain once had much thicker, softer layers of rock above it, but these eroded away to produce the flat top. This is often enveloped in a "tablecloth" of clouds, formed when onshore winds are directed up the mountain's slopes into colder air, where the moisture they carry condenses.



△ SUNSET VIEW

Table Mountain is seen here covered by its "tablecloth" of white clouds just before sunset. Below and to its left are the lights of Cape Town and to the right lies the suburb of Camps Bay.

◁ ICONIC FLORA

Also known as the Pride of Table Mountain, the spectacular Red Disa orchid typically grows near streams and waterfalls. It is the emblem of South Africa's Cape Province.

INSIDE TABLE MOUNTAIN

The mountain's upper part is a 2,000-ft- (600-m-) thick slab of hard sandstone, around 450 million years old. This lies above several layers of sedimentary rock, except at one end, where there is a large granite intrusion.

